These much-quoted lines to all intents sanctified the Brahmins, the priests of the Arya, as the mouth-piece of Brahma, through whom the Arya received their God-given laws, along with the God-given social order known as *varna*, a vexatious word which, thanks to the Portuguese, is usually translated as ‘caste’, although it can equally be interpreted as ‘race’, ‘class of men’ or even ‘colour’. On the second rung of the *varna* ladder were those named in the *Purusha Sukta* as Rajanyas, or ‘those who rule’, better known as Kshatriyas, destined by birth to rule and fight. Below them, but also considered worthy to undergo the *upanayana samskara*, the sacred thread ceremony that proclaimed them as ‘twice-born’, were the Vaishyas, the merchants and agriculturalists. Lastly, the Shudras, who made up the Arya labour force. But even they shared the birth privilege of *varna*, perhaps reflecting shared origins outside India. All the rest of humankind were *avarna*, or ‘non-*varna*’, destined always to be outsiders and outcastes.

So the Dasas remained outside the law, with no prospect of ever being accepted into the fold. We can assume that many had no option but to bend the knee and accept their fate. But others, we can equally assume, withdrew deeper into the forests and highlands, including those who migrated south across the Narmada. As far as the Arya were concerned, what lay beyond the Narmada, the Dakshina, was still unknown country, wild and hostile, and dominated by demons and demon armies.

There is so much to marvel at in the complexities of the Vedas and Vedanta. But we should also bear in mind that this was all the work of Brahmin priests and thinkers – created out of piety, certainly, but very much to their advantage. The Brahmin caste remains to this day the oldest and longest-lasting closed shop in history. For all the abuse that has been heaped upon them in recent years – and particularly in the Tamil-speaking regions – the Brahmins were, and still are, a quite astonishing